

Endurance bus trip has baseball, trivia—and friends

By Edgar Williams

It was 3 o'clock in the morning and all through the bus not a creature was stirring except for the driver. Then suddenly a voice brought excitement out of the night.

"Trivia time!" a man named David Spillane yelled. "Who was the manager of the Phillies just before Gene Mauch?"

Whereupon the 23 other passengers, most of them aroused from slumber, began flinging names around like a conglomeration of gossipy columnists. Pretty soon somebody yelled "Andy Cohen," who handled the Phils in one game in 1960 while Mauch was en route to Philadelphia to succeed Eddie Sawyer.

"Not bad," Spillane said. "Now let's keep the game going." And so they did, these people aboard a bus knifing through the night, pilgrims on what may have been the oddest odyssey since Geoffrey Chaucer lyricized about a road trip to Canterbury.

This was a group of baseball buffs, doing what every genuine fibbert has always yearned to do — making a "dream swing" through both major leagues. They hit the road Aug. 1, and when it all ended Sunday in Chicago where the Cubs and the Montreal Expos were booked for battle, they had traveled about 3,400 miles, been in 10 different ballparks and seen 17 different teams.

Also, they toured the Baseball Hall of Fame in Cooperstown, N. Y., and the Babe Ruth Shrine in Baltimore, and some of them worshipped at the feet of Billy Martin at a pub in Cleveland, where the feisty manager of the Oakland A's held court after a game between the A's and the Indians had been rained out.

And all of this — not to mention accommodations in first-class hotels for seven nights (because of schedule-tightness there were two overnight bus jumps), 21 meals and, for beer drinkers, a never-dries-up supply of sodas aboard the bus — for \$849 (\$969 for single occupancy).

"It was," said David Spillane, 55, who lives in Bryn Mawr, Pa., and is a manufacturers' representative, "the best vacation bargain I've ever run across. It was more than a baseball trip. It was a people trip — real, genuine people with a common interest. I found it unbelievably relaxing."

The group might be termed America in cross-section. The age range ran from Kerry Nigemyer, 12, a tomboy from Toledo, Ohio, to Floyd Wilson, 71, a retired engineer from Westport, Conn. There were seven females. There was a sportswriter from Carbondale, Ill., whose ulcer flared up a day after the tour began but who hung in there on warm milk, crackers and true grit.

There were three people from Arizona.

There was a steel worker from Gary, Ind. There were a recent graduate of Yale Law School and a bookkeeper from Lincoln, Neb., who for diversion frequently flings herself out of aircraft, with benefit of parachute.

And there was Charles "Chuck" Laterza, a young man from Fremont, Ohio, who conceived the idea, brought it off with the class of a Grade A travel agent and wound up about \$700 in the bucket. But he does not repine.

"I laid out a little more money than I had figured for meals, because I just couldn't ask anybody to limit themselves to specific items on menus," said Laterza, 26, who is treasurer of the Clyde (Ohio) Board of Education, a job that in Ohio public schools is on a par with that of superintendent. "I always wanted to make a trip like this, so I can't complain about running a few hundred dollars over budget."

As Laterza tells it, he comes honestly by his ardor for baseball. His late father was an all-star buff, with a special love for baseball, and as young Chuck grew up, he had no choice but to learn the lore.

"My mother used to say that if Dad had taught me as much about religion as he did about sports, I would have had a shot at becoming pope," Laterza said. "I think that he organized it, he believed to be a first-of-its-kind. There have, of course, been excursions during which fans have traveled to see their favorite teams play on the road, but there appears to have been no previous tour that has taken fans to so many different cities."

Laterza spent \$150 on advertising — all of it for one ad last January in the Sporting News, the national baseball weekly. The wire services picked up the story and soon Laterza heard receiving calls from throughout the nation. He whipped up a mimeographed flier, in which he stressed that "there will be at least two all-night bus trips, therefore endurance is a MUST."

By July 1, one month before the first game of the tour in Detroit between the Tigers and Seattle, he had 30 registrations; subsequently, there were six cancellations. When the group left Toledo Aug. 1 aboard a 38-passenger bus, from which four seats had been removed to provide room for the beer cooler on one side and a table for bridge on the other, there was a lot of getting acquainted to do.

Aside from two married couples — Cecil and Georgia Crough, 54 and 52 respectively, of Casa Grande, Ariz., and Robert and Sandra Miller, 57 and 39, from New York — and the granddaughter-grandmother pair of young Kerry Nigemyer and Virginia Wilcox, 64, of Waynesburg, Pa. — nobody knew anybody else. But, all agree, in an astonishingly short time they came to feel that they had been together for weeks.

This was evident when I joined the group in Boston last Tuesday. By then

they had attended games in Detroit and New York (Sunday at Shea Stadium, where the Mets played Houston, and Monday at Yankee Stadium, where it was the Yanks against Texas), and as we got acquainted during lunch at Jimmy's Harborside Restaurant, it was almost as if these folks were old, old friends who were welcoming a newcomer into their midst.

So if these observations take on a slightly irrational quality, attribute it to residence among amiable people gone dippy about a game that small boys can play. We journeyed together for a couple of days, and the journey was neither a straight nor a narrow path but pleasantly meandering and as leisurely as the drift of a summer cloud. It was a trip steeped in fun, singing with fiddle music and waist-deep in comestibles and potables.

The Boston Red Sox were to play the Milwaukee Brewers that evening at wondrous Fenway Park, with its famous "Green Monster" left field wall and its single-deck grandstand. On the way to the sweaty exercises, various members of the group came to the front of the bus and made little speeches or asked trivia questions — always about baseball.

"Anybody tries to talk football or anything like that, we tell him to get lost," said Charlie Morris, 30, from Elyria, Ohio, a construction worker who likes to quip that "if I ever stop drinking beer, they'll have to lay off the second shift at a dozen breweries."

Later, viewing the Fenway grass, as tenderly manicured as a Powers Model, Morris nodded approvingly. "This," he announced to those about him, "is the way God intended baseball to be played — on grass."

After the game there was a visit to the Top of the Hub, a cocktail lounge 52 stories above center city Boston. Not everyone went there, however. Jim Woodward, 15, of Luna Pier, Mich., chose to go to the Sheraton Hotel nearby, where the Milwaukee team was staying, in quest of autographs.

This is a kid who would ask a gorilla for an autograph. He is a walking encyclopedia of baseball and the quintessential Detroit Tiger fan. "My room at home," he said, "is done in contemporary Tiger, all blue and orange." Ten years from now, Jim tells you firmly, he will be the TV-radio voice of the Tigers. On this trip he was the official broadcaster aboard the bus, getting on the p.a. system to give scores and deliver commentaries.

Shortly after midnight, Laterza shepherded everybody aboard the bus for an all-night ride to Cooperstown. Kerry Nigemyer said she was sad because the Pittsburgh Pirates ("I dearly love them") had lost to the Cubs, and Mrs. Wilcox, Kerry's grandmother, got to talking about why she and the girl had come on the trip.

"I read about the tour in the paper, and I thought it would be something I could do for Kerry, bringing her on this

trip," Mrs. Wilcox said. "Well, my daughter thinks I'm crazy, but I'm having fun, and so is Kerry."

Sam Magdovitz, 25, of Toledo, who recently was graduated from Yale Law School, said he was on the trip because "my parents gave me a pretty expensive birthday present." Magdovitz, soon to join the staff of the Manhattan district attorney in New York, said he was looking forward to seeing his favorite team, the St. Louis Cardinals, play the Phillies at Veterans Stadium Wednesday.

Rolling along, headed for Cooperstown, the group not only played 3 a.m. baseball trivia but decided at about 4 a.m. to pick an all-time all-star team. Jim Woodward supervised the balloting, and the club these buffs picked is an impressive one:

Mickey Cochrane, catcher; Lou Gehrig, first base; Rodgers Hornsby, second base; Hans Wagner, shortstop; Brooks Robinson, third base; Ty Cobb, Babe Ruth and Willie Mays, outfielders; and two pitchers, Walter Johnson and Bob Feller.

In Cooperstown, the group breakfasted at a Main Street establishment called the Short Stop Restaurant, then went to the Hall of Fame. Linda Biggam, 21, from Phoenix, Ariz., a senior at Arizona State University, said she was "thrilled." Brad Betker, 23, the sportswriter from the Southern Illinoisan, Carbondale, Ill., said that "ulcer or no ulcer, I wouldn't have missed this." And Leota Janousek, 42, the bookkeeper-sky diver from Nebraska, was especially taken by the Babe Ruth exhibit.

On the way out of town, the group stopped at Doubleday Field, where baseball is said to have been born. The sight of this historic cow pasture inspired Andy Rabinowitz, 21, of Clifton, N. J., a communications major at Boston University, to go buckety-bucket around the bases, finishing with a gloriously dusty slide into home plate. Rabinowitz was wearing shorts and he uttered a one-word comment concerning his feat.

"Ouch!" Then it was on to Philadelphia. The group arrived at Veterans Stadium at 5 o'clock, just in time to be escorted onto the field for a close-up view of the Phillies' batting practice. Some of the Cardinals had come out early, and Jim Woodward and the other autograph-seekers in the group found Jim Kaat, Terry Kennedy, Mike Phillips and Dane Long accommodated.

Next order of business was to check in at the Stadium Hilton Inn, where showers were taken and clothes were changed. Then it was back to the Vet to see what, lamentably for these fans on a "dream swing," had to be the most underwhelming performance by a Phillies' team since the time of Vance Dinges, the lord of the pop flies, who played first base here 35 years ago. The Phils got creamed, 14-0.

Back at the Stadium Hilton after the game, the group held a post mortem. "It

was pretty bad," said Mike Mahon, 25, of Vermillion, S.D., sports information director of the University of South Dakota, who described his participation in the tour as a kind of husman's holiday. "But the way this game goes, the Phillies could turn around and do the same thing to the Pirates when we see them in Pittsburgh Friday night."

Next morning, the group headed for Baltimore, where they would see the Orioles play the Chicago White Sox that night. Then would come the Phillies and

Pittsburgh on Friday, Los Angeles at Cincinnati Saturday and the Cubs-Expos Sunday. The "dream swing" was nearing its end and it was obvious that everybody wished it could go on and on.

"Not just for the baseball," said Randall Palmer, 55, the steel worker from Gary, the only black in the group. "Look, I've been in a lot of places and I've met a lot of people and I'll tell you something — this is the best bunch I've ever been with. Baseball fans, they're the most beautiful people in the world."

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